



US00PP36232P2

(12) **United States Plant Patent**
MacKenzie

(10) **Patent No.:** **US PP36,232 P2**
(45) **Date of Patent:** **Oct. 29, 2024**

(54) **PANICUM PLANT NAMED ‘Nondee’**

(50) Latin Name: *Panicum virgatum*
Varietal Denomination: **Nondee**

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(*) Notice: Subject to any disclaimer, the term of this patent is extended or adjusted under 35 U.S.C. 154(b) by 0 days.

(21) Appl. No.: **18/420,900**

(22) Filed: **Jan. 24, 2024**

(51) **Int. Cl.**
A01H 5/12 (2018.01)
A01H 6/46 (2018.01)

(52) **U.S. Cl.**
USPC **Plt./384**

(58) **Field of Classification Search**
USPC **Plt./384**
See application file for complete search history.

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(57) **ABSTRACT**

A new cultivar of *Panicum* plant named ‘Nondee’ that is characterized by its rounded and upright plant habit with nonlodging clumping foliage with upright flowering spikes above foliage, its average of 61 cm in foliage height, 1.2 m in inflorescence height and 1.2 m in spread in the landscape, its foliage that green in color and becomes flushed with purple in autumn, its flowering period from August to October in Michigan, and its flowers that are maroon-purple in color.

1 Drawing Sheet

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Botanical classification: *Panicum virgatum*.
Varietal denomination: ‘Nondee’.

BACKGROUND OF THE INVENTION

The present invention relates to a new and distinct cultivar of *Panicum virgatum* and will be referred to hereafter by its cultivar name, ‘Nondee’. ‘Nondee’ represents a new cultivar of switchgrass, an ornamental grass grown for landscape use.

The new cultivar of *Panicum* was derived from an ongoing controlled breeding program conducted by the Inventor in Nunica, Michigan. The goals of the breeding program include developing new cultivars of *Panicum* with novel ornamental traits that include strong stature, compact habits, and unique foliage or flower colors.

‘Nondee’ originated as a seedling that arose from open pollination in a production field containing numerous cultivars and proprietary seedlings of *Panicum virgatum* varieties at the Inventors’ nursery in September of 2019. The collected seeds were pooled prior to planting in an evaluation field plot and therefore the parentage is unknown. ‘Nondee’ was selected as a single unique plant in September of 2021 from amongst the resulting seedlings.

Asexual propagation of the new cultivar was first accomplished by the Inventor by division in Nunica, Michigan in September of 2021. Asexual propagation by division and tissue culture using meristematic tissue has determined that the characteristics of the new cultivar are stable and are reproduced true to type in successive generations.

SUMMARY OF THE INVENTION

The following traits have been repeatedly observed and represent the characteristics of the new cultivar. These attributes in combination distinguish ‘Nondee’ as a unique cultivar of *Panicum*.

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1. ‘Nondee’ exhibits a rounded and upright plant habit with nonlodging clumping foliage with upright flowering spikes above foliage.
2. ‘Nondee’ exhibits an average of 61 cm in foliage height, 1.2 m in inflorescence height and 1.2 m in spread in the landscape.
3. ‘Nondee’ exhibits foliage that green in color and becomes flushed with purple in autumn.
4. ‘Nondee’ exhibits a flowering period from August to October in Michigan.
5. ‘Nondee’ exhibits flowers that are maroon-purple in color.

‘Nondee’ can be most closely compared to *Panicum virgatum* cultivars, ‘Cape Breeze’ (U.S. Plant Pat. No. 24,895), and ‘Rotstrahlbusch’ (not patented). ‘Cape Breeze’ is similar to ‘Nondee’ in having a compact habit and heavy blooming. ‘Cape Breeze’ differs from ‘Nondee’ in having a shorter plant height, silver flowers, and a less rounded plant habit. ‘Rotstrahlbusch’ is similar to ‘Nondee’ in having foliage that changes in color in fall. ‘Rotstrahlbusch’ is different from ‘Nondee’ in having a less rounded plant habit, fall foliage that is flushed more red in color, flowers that are amber in color, and flower panicles that are less dense.

STATEMENT REGARDING PRIOR DISCLOSURES BY THE INVENTOR

The Applicant asserts that no publications or advertisements relating to sales, offers for sale, or public distribution occurred more than one year prior to the effective filing date of this application. Any information about the claimed plant would have been obtained from a direct or indirect disclosure from the Inventor. The Applicant claims a prior art exemption under 35 U.S.C. 102(b)(1) for disclosures and/or sales that fall within a one-year grace period to the filing date. Disclosures include a website listing by Hortech.

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWING

The accompanying color photograph illustrates the overall appearance and distinct characteristics of the new *Pani-*

cum. The photograph was taken of a 5-year-old plant of 'Nondee' as grown outdoors in a trial garden in Nunica, Michigan. The photograph provides a side view of 'Nondee' in bloom. The colors in the photograph are as close as possible with the photographic and printing technology utilized and the color values cited in the Detailed Botanical Description accurately describe the colors of the new *Panicum*.

DETAILED BOTANICAL DESCRIPTION OF THE PLANT

The following is a detailed description of five-year-old plants of the new cultivar as grown outdoors in a trial garden in Nunica, Michigan. The phenotype of the new cultivar may vary with variations in environmental, climatic, and cultural conditions, as it has not been tested under all possible environmental conditions. The color determination is in accordance with The 1986 Royal Horticultural Society Colour Chart, London, England, except where general color terms of ordinary dictionary significance are used.

General description:

Blooming period.—From August until October in Michigan.

Plant type.—Herbaceous perennial grass.

Plant habit.—Upright, rounded, nonlodging clumping foliage with upright flowering spikes above foliage.

Height and width or spread.—An average of 9.1 m in height (including inflorescences) and 12.2 m in spread as grown in the landscape for 5 years. An average of 61 cm in foliage height, 1.2 m in inflorescence height and 1.2 m in spread as grown in the landscape for 5 years.

Hardiness zone.—At least in U.S.D.A. zones 4 to 9.

Diseases.—Good resistance to rust (caused by *Puccinia emaculata*) has been observed.

Root description.—Fibrous and fine, deeply rooted, a blend between 161A and 164C in color.

Propagation.—Rhizome division.

Rhizomes.—An average of 3 cm in length and 0.5 cm width, 155A in color.

Growth rate.—Moderate for a *Panicum*.

Time required for root development.—From 2-inch wide divisions; up to 4 weeks for root initiation with a fully rooted plant in a 3.5-inch container produced in an average of 6 weeks.

Culm (stem) description:

General.—Cylindrical, hollow pith, thin but strong, held erect.

Culm number.—An average of 8 in an 8-cm container, forming a tight clump.

Culm color.—Summer; a blend of 137C to 137D, autumn and winter; 162A, base 161B to 161C and ranges from 6.4 cm to 10.2 cm of exposed area between leaf nodes.

Culm size.—An average of 3.2 mm in diameter and 33 cm in height from the base to the base of the peduncle.

Culm surface.—Glabrous, smooth, and slightly striate.

Internode length.—An average of 7.6 cm.

Foliage description:

Leaf shape.—Narrowly lanceolate.

Leaf division.—Simple.

Leaf margin.—Entire, scaberulous.

Leaf base.—Sheathed to base of the node.

Leaf venation.—Parallel, not distinguishable in color from leaf coloration.

Leaf width.—An average of 0.64 cm at widest section.

Leaf length.—Blade; an average of 25.4 cm, sheathed portion; an average of 10.2 cm.

Leaves per culm.—An average of 4 on flowering culms.

Leaf color.—Upper and lower surfaces a blend of 137A and 137B.

Leaf surface.—Glabrous, dull, and slightly striate on both surfaces.

Ligule.—An average of 3.2 mm in height and 1.6 mm in width, color on both surfaces; 160D at the top, covered in fine hairs on the on inner surface that protrude from the top, 160D in color.

Flower description:

Inflorescence type.—Dense, spreading panicle at terminus of stem, symmetrical, typically 6-flowered spikelet with lower spikelet male and upper spikelet hermaphroditic.

Inflorescence color.—In early summer; 138B, later summer; maturing to 59A, autumn; turns to 165C.

Inflorescence size.—An average of 21.6 cm in length and 18.4 cm in width.

Inflorescence arrangement.—Upright.

Spikelet description.—An average of 150 per panicle, oval to elliptic in shape, an average of 1.3 mm in length and 6.4 mm in width, awn present; an average of 0.5 mm in length and 61A in color, lower glume; an average of 4 mm in length and 1 mm in width, upper glume and lower lemma; an average of 4.5 cm in length and 1 mm width, color; glumes and lemma upper and lower surface a blend between 144D and 157B suffused with 165B near the base, palea; an average of 1.5 mm in length and 0.5 mm in width, translucent and glossy, color a blend of 155C and 157D, glumes, lemma, and palea are oval to elliptic in shape and convex with all surfaces glabrous and smooth.

Rachis.—An average of 10.2 cm in length from last leaf, raceme portion; an average of 27 cm in length and 1 mm in width, glabrous and smooth surface, a blend of 138B and 143B in color, lateral branches (peduncle-like); an average of 7, about 0.2 mm in width and an average of 18 cm in length (shortest at terminus), 137C in color, glabrous surface, pedicel; an average of 5 mm in length and 0.2 mm in width, very fine and wiry, 138B in color, glabrous surface.

Reproductive organs:

Androecium.—Anthers; 3, an average of 1.5 mm in length, 0.5 mm in width, 172A in color, filament; basifixed, very fine, translucent, pollen; moderate in quantity and 162C in color.

Gynoecium.—Pistil; 1, stigmas; 2, plumose on short fine styles adnate to ovary, N79B to N79C in color, an average of 2 mm in length and 0.5 mm in width, ovary; 1-locular, superior, an average of 3 mm in length and 0.5 mm in with, 149D in color.

It is claimed:

1. A new and distinct cultivar of *Panicum* plant named 'Nondee' as herein illustrated and described.

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